

allowing us much more free-dom than I expected or deserved. It turned out that father needed it. He was nip and tuck with death twice more before finally pulling through, including requiring on very short notice an emergency proce-dure that drained a quart and a half of fluid from his lung by needle injunc-tion and vacuum removal. The fluid had filled his lungs almost instantly. Without our dedicated crew to catch it fast, he would not have survived. But all this trauma beat up his body and mind.

The entire crisis, which included several small strokes, was still another floodgate for the dementia to pour through en masse. Still, this old man's tough body recovered enough to where he could walk several miles a day and talk clearly at length, even if he couldn't remember many things. By then, however, he had forgotten pretty much every-thing after about 1968. Slowly, as dementia does, his long-term memo-ries became only about older and older events. He is at the stage now where he recalls very little and recognizes very few people, typical of late dementia. The slide was a slow, irregular decline that felt amazingly swift to all of us as it occurred every few months. The only people he always knows now are my mother and me. It shocked me when he first failed to recognize Arthur, his favorite son, whom he now sometimes knows and sometimes doesn't. He remembers me because he sees me more often and long has. At home, with around-the-clock in-home help, he is bedridden, unable to walk, lacking his favorite activities of most of his life—the walking, the worrying, and the third “W,” working. I take care of pretty much everything in terms of health care, finances, and so on for both him and my mother. While my mother is still pretty vital, my father isn't the man I knew. Not at all. The man I knew is long gone.

Today my mother puts in endless time on him but struggles under the burden. Despite his health care providers doing an overall great job for him, she never feels it is good enough and regularly injects herself into the middle, which ultimately drains her to exhaustion. Then, with her away, he starts calling out for her, and it is very tough on her and on everyone. I can't tell how much of a curse and how much of a blessing it will be for her when he finally passes on. It is impossible to tell. The only thing I know for sure is that old age isn't for sissies.

They had eleven grandchildren and four great-grandchildren. The first grandchild was named after my aunt who was named after Aunt Cary. The